

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

V

Violation of the Sacred

Violation of the sacred is the act of disrespecting, damaging, or misusing something that is considered holy or set apart for God. Ever since the early days in the garden of Eden, humans have tried to claim God's holy space as their own (Genesis 2:15-17; 3:1-6).

The Bible shows God's anger and quick punishment when people fail to respect his holy commands. God called Nadab and Abihu to lead Israel in proper worship. When they ignored God's specific instructions about priestly duties, they died for their sin (Leviticus 10:1-20). Jesus showed God's righteous anger when he entered the temple with a whip. He chased out the merchants and money changers who were polluting the holy space for profit (John 2:13-16).

No one could violate God's holy presence, including in the temple in Jerusalem. The temple represented God's presence in the world, so all its ceremonies had to show its holy status. Only those anointed for the task could enter to make offerings.

One serious mistake was when King Uzziah "entered the temple of the LORD to burn incense on the altar of incense" (2 Chronicles 26:16). Unlike kings from other ancient Near Eastern cultures, Israel's kings could not enter the holy space. God anointed them only for government duties. The king of Israel was not a priest nor could he represent God in holy matters. He was not a god, unlike in other cultures.

He was a servant of God chosen from his people for "carefully observing" the covenant in the community (Deuteronomy 17:18-20). When King Uzziah tried to act in a priestly role that did not belong to him, he violated the holy place set apart for God's presence. This violation was a serious matter related to the function of the temple.

King David shows humility compared to Uzziah's pride (1 Samuel 21:1-9). When his men were hungry, David knew there was bread at the tabernacle. Instead of taking it, he asked the priest, who gave them the holy bread with his blessing.

In contrast, Uzziah entered the temple and showed no respect for this holy space (26:16). He thought that, as king, he could enter God's temple. Yet, he did not have that right. God punished him with a skin disease and separation from daily life. This punishment matched the pride of his actions.

The temptation to act like Uzziah, who showed no respect for holy things, is always present. Any action that fails to honor God, shows no respect for his holy space. Human history is about God restoring the heavens and earth to be his home.

In the new covenant through Jesus Christ, God's holy space is not just a temple in Jerusalem or any building. He sets apart the lives of those who trust him (1 Corinthians 6:19-20). Through his grace, God makes the people of the new covenant his temple on earth (1 Peter 2:4-5). They become the place where his holiness enters creation. History will be complete when all of heaven and earth become God's temple (Isaiah 65:17-18; Revelation 21:1-2).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 2:15-17; 3:1-6; Exodus 19:12-13; 31:14-15; Leviticus 10:1-20; 24:16-17; Numbers 1:51; 15:32-36; 2 Chronicles 26:16-21; 1 Corinthians 6:19-20

Visions

Visions are similar to other experiences of God's revelation, like dreams (Genesis 37:5-10; 40:5-19). Classic examples include the prophet Ezekiel's vision of the valley of dry bones and the prophet Isaiah's vision of God's throne (Ezekiel 37:1-14; Isaiah 6). Old Testament prophets often received messages from the Lord through visions. The visions in the Bible often showed powerful and memorable pictures that helped people understand God's message. In these visions, God showed special pictures or scenes that had deeper meanings about real things happening on earth. God or an angel would then explain to the person what these pictures meant.

Visions are important in the book of Acts and often occur during prayer (Acts 9:10-12; 16:9-10; 22:17-21; 23:11; see Luke 1:8-20). In one instance, an angel visited Cornelius, a Roman officer (Acts 10:1-6, 30-32). The angel told him to send for the apostle Peter. The next day, as Peter prayed, he had a vision (10:9-16; see 11:5-10). It was connected to his meeting with Cornelius.

In Acts 9, the visions of the apostle Paul and Ananias also show God's role in their lives (9:3-6, 10-16). These visions are not by accident but part of God's plan to save the world.

Visions provide divine guidance and show Christian workers how to fulfill the Great Commission.

Paul experienced several visions:

- during his conversion on the Damascus road (Acts 9:3-6; 22:6-10; 26:12-19)
- before his missionary journey to Europe (16:9)

- in Corinth (18:9–11)
- in the temple (22:17–21)
- in Jerusalem before his trip to Rome (23:11)

14:24–45; Psalm 76:11; Proverbs 20:25; Ecclesiastes 5:3–5; Malachi 1:14; Matthew 5:33–37; Acts 18:18; 21:23–24; James 5:12

Through visions, God actively guides the church's activities and expands its mission (see the study notes on Acts 10:3, 9–16; 22:17–22; 23:11; see also Galatians 1:8–9 and study note there).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 37:5–10; 40:1–41:36; Isaiah 6:1–13; Jeremiah 14:14; Ezekiel 37:1–14; Daniel 8:1–27; 9:21; Hosea 12:10; Obadiah 1:1; Habakkuk 2:3; Luke 1:8–20; Acts 9:3–6, 10–16; 10:3–6, 9–16, 30–32; 11:5–9; 16:9–10; 18:9–11; 22:6–10, 17–21; 23:11; 26:14–19; 2 Corinthians 12:1–10; Revelation 1:9–22:7

Vows to God

A vow to God means something like saying, “If God does ‘this’, then I will give ‘this’ to God or his holy place.”

Examples include:

- Jacob gave a tenth of his earnings (Genesis 28:20–22).
- The Israelites promised to give God the Canaanite war spoils (Numbers 21:2).
- Hannah committed to giving her son as a lifelong servant to the Lord (1 Samuel 1:11).
- Absalom offered sacrifices to God at Hebron (2 Samuel 15:8).

The sacrificial laws often mention rules for vows. Israelites made vows based on God answering their requests. They would then fulfill their vows to God, often by giving offerings (for example, Leviticus 7:16; 22:23; Deuteronomy 12:11).

Yet, people could take advantage of vows. The law itself warns against this (Deuteronomy 23:21–23). So do the wisdom teachings (for example, Proverbs 7:10–14; 20:25). Also, the books of the prophets (see, for example, Jeremiah 44:25).

King Saul often made foolish vows (1 Samuel 14:24–28). He did not keep the vows he made (19:6). People might not fulfill or repay careless vows. This could cause God to punish them. It is better not to make a vow than to break one (Ecclesiastes 5:3–5). Jesus commands us to live with such honesty and integrity that we do not need to make vows (Matthew 5:33–37; compare James 5:12).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 28:20–22; Numbers 21:2–3; 30:1–16; Deuteronomy 23:18–23; Judges 11:30–40; 1 Samuel 1:11, 24–28;